Hello, I’m Edahn.

This website is about me both professionally and personally. What I aspire to, what I care about deeply, and what I wonder about.

Let’s start with what I think really drives me, my values.

- Helping others
- Discovering truth
- Finding meaning and peace
- Joy, celebration, and spirit
- Intelligence
- Harmony

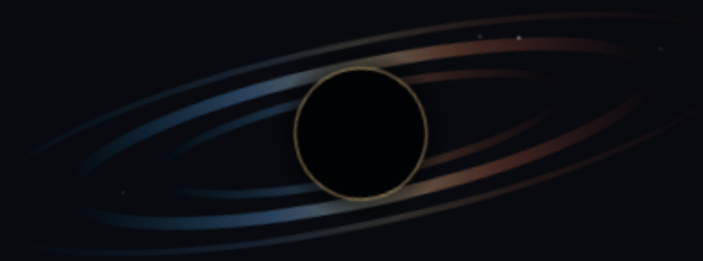
I wonder a lot about a lot of things.

When I was 13 I became fascinated with space and black holes and the edge between science and science fiction. That never stopped.

I like to wonder about reality: why it exists at all, what it really is, deep down, and what that means for me, my life and my relationship to the whole.

WHERE THAT STARTED

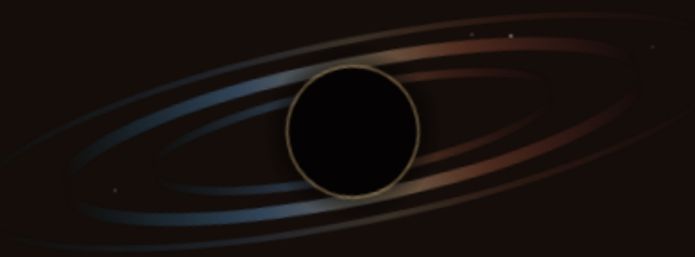
I attended religious day school but sometime in 10th grade started turning to science for explanations about why things were the way they were instead of religion. That led to a deeper interest in science and cosmology specifically.



I’m also interested in Zen, and have practiced for about 20 years.

I’m currently a dharma teacher in the Kwan Um School of Zen, a Korean-American tradition founded by Zen Master Seung Sahn. Zen is a place where I explore how to live, and how the mind influences our ideas about others and reality and even notions of who or what we are. I attend long retreats semi-regularly to explore these questions carefully.

Zen practice has deeply influenced how I understand notions of self, my role in life, and the nature of intimacy, spirituality, and peace.



THE FUNDAMENTAL INQUIRY

When you say “I have” or “give it to me,” what are the I/me pronouns actually referring to?

As soon as you try to grab it, it slips away and becomes something else.

WHAT YOU FIND

We have an idea about who we are. We think we’re the thing that’s animating the body, or the ongoing stream of thoughts that dominates our consciousness. But can you see it? Can you catch it? Hold it? When you try you find it impossible. As soon as you try to grab it it slips away and becomes something else.

In deep silence you can look directly at that question and see the impermanence that pervades the entire universe and you too. You can see that nothing is actually made up of itself. It’s made up of different things that are changing. Your self is like that too. What I see is not me but the world outside, just like what I see and touch, and it’s all changing.

Ultimately one can perceive that the I/me (subject) that’s separate from what’s perceived (the object) is just a hallucination. There is no distinction. In Zen we say “inside and outside have become one.” If you try to think about it, it won’t make sense. It has to be viewed in the context of

Zen has also influenced my views on psychotherapy and psychology, not from dogma but my own experiences.

I’ve been developing my own theory called Narrative Theory. (The name just kinda happened.)

In a nutshell, it’s a way to systematically think about how we construct stories (narratives) about ourselves, others, the future, and situations, how to document and classify those stories, and how those stories interact with other stories (narrative dynamics).

I’m not just a nerd, I promise.

I like celebration, humor, and creativity. I’m a regular at the Venice Beach drum circle (I play djembe) and yes, I’ve attended Burning Man.

I also love my family. We have a very large extended family who I adore.

I’m into AI and tech, and am curious about the intersection of AI and everything.

But specifically therapy, Zen, art, and data analysis (nerd alert again!).

Some of my recent projects →

AI

I like to write, even though I never really considered myself a good writer.

Writing within flow is incredibly enjoyable.

Ideas and opinions →

THE BACK CATALOGUE

I've had an advice column and countless blogs. My favorite was a short-lived one called Darwin's Mirror, about animals and humans engaged in the same behavior, back when I was very into human ethology.

Edahn Small

I’m also a contender for the world’s best uncle.

UNCLE

I live in Los Angeles and practice therapy online.

My main work is in data design and now AI. I’m an ex-lawyer as well. Didn’t enjoy fighting as much as I enjoy spirited debate, apparently.

About my therapy practice →

If you want to learn more, have a good conversation, and talk therapy, please reach out.

I’d love to hear from you.

Email me

AI projects

I’m curious about the intersection of AI and everything, but specifically therapy, Zen, art, and data analysis. Here’s what that has turned into so far.

LIVE

Narrative Theory: the program

A five-stage guided program that maps the dream your thinking has built, then works on it. An AI guide listens, proposes a structure, and draws you a map you can argue with.

TRY IT →

LIVE

Narrative Theory: the framework

The written theory — modes, Saran Wrap, energy states, scoring systems — plus the mode library and the Life Instruction modules.

READ IT →

SLOT 1

Waiting on a repo

A title, two sentences, a link, and a tag. Send the GitHub URL or the demo and this becomes a real card.

EMPTY

SLOT 2

Waiting on a repo

A title, two sentences, a link, and a tag. Send the GitHub URL or the demo and this becomes a real card.

EMPTY

SLOT 3

Waiting on a repo

A title, two sentences, a link, and a tag. Send the GitHub URL or the demo and this becomes a real card.

EMPTY

SLOT 4

Waiting on a repo

A title, two sentences, a link, and a tag. Send the GitHub URL or the demo and this becomes a real card.

EMPTY

For Edahn: the two live cards are real. The four striped ones are placeholders. Send repo links, demo URLs, or just titles and a line each, and they fill in — the grid grows to whatever number you give me.

Therapy

I live in Los Angeles and practise therapy online. Here’s roughly how I think about the work, and who it tends to suit.

How I work

My approach comes out of two things that have run alongside each other for twenty years: Zen practice, and a long argument with contemporary psychotherapy. Not from dogma on either side — from my own experience of what actually shifts something and what only sounds like it does.

The working assumption is that most suffering runs through a story. We construct narratives about ourselves, other people, the future, and whatever situation we’re in, and then we live inside them as though we’d found them rather than made them. The work is learning to see the story as a story — which is a different skill from having a better one.

So I’m less interested in reframing than in looking directly. What’s actually happening, what you’re making it mean, and what that reliably costs you. I’ll tell you what I think rather than reflect everything back, and I’d rather be corrected than agreed with.

I’ve written the theory behind this up in some detail if you want to see the machinery before you decide.

Read Narrative Theory → **Or try the guided program →**

Who I see

Individuals	Anyone who comes to it sincerely. You don’t need a diagnosis, a crisis, or a tidy explanation of what’s wrong — wanting to look at something honestly is enough.
Couples	Yes. Often the most useful work is watching two narratives collide in real time, which is difficult to do alone.
Where	Online. I’m based in Los Angeles.
Who this isn’t for	If you’re at high risk of suicide, this isn’t the right setting, and I’ll say so rather than take you on. That needs care that can reach you physically and quickly.

For Edahn: this page carries no licence details, fees, insurance, session length, or availability, because I don’t have them and won’t guess on a therapy page. Send them and I’ll add a practical section. Same for anything above that misstates how you actually work — I wrote it from what you told me in chat.

If you’re curious, write to me.

Tell me a bit about what’s going on, or don’t — “I’d like to talk” is a perfectly good first message. I read everything that comes in.

Get in touch →

Ideas and opinions

I like to write, even though I never really considered myself a good writer. Writing within flow is incredibly enjoyable. This is where that goes.

What I keep coming back to

SUBJECT

Zen

Practice, retreats, and what twenty years of sitting does and doesn’t do to a person.

NO POSTS YET

SUBJECT

Reality

Cosmology, physics, and the edge where science starts sounding like science fiction.

NO POSTS YET

SUBJECT

Narrative Theory

The theory as it develops — modes, Saran Wrap, scoring systems, narrative dynamics.

NO POSTS YET

SUBJECT

Therapy

What the field gets right, what it keeps getting wrong, and what happens in the room.

NO POSTS YET

SUBJECT

AI

Building with it, thinking about it, and the parts that are genuinely strange.

NO POSTS YET

SUBJECT

Animals and us

Human ethology — the Darwin’s Mirror territory. Animals and humans caught doing exactly the same thing.

NO POSTS YET

Previously

I’ve had an advice column and countless blogs. My favorite was a short-lived one called **Darwin’s Mirror**, about animals and humans engaged in the same behavior, back when I was very into human ethology.

For Edahn: no posts are invented here — the six subjects are real, the archive line is yours. Send writing (drafts, old posts, links to anything still online) and this becomes a proper index with the subjects as filters. If you’d rather it read as a feed than a grid, say so and I’ll rebuild it that way.

Introducing Narrative Theory

How the mind builds the world you live in — and how to see it happening.

Years ago, a therapy client came in a week apart as two different people. Nothing in her life had changed — same job, same relationship, same apartment. The first week, all of it was good. The next week, none of it mattered.

The facts held still. The story collapsed.

That's the thing this site is about: you don't live in the world. You live in a construction of it — built from stories about yourself, other people, the future, and every situation you're in. The construction changes with your state, shows up in your body, and never announces itself. It always feels like plain reality.

Scroll, and watch one get built.

STAGE 1 / 12

Start with two things.

A person, and something the person is looking at. A partner. A situation. Sometimes the target is yourself.

The Target · A Situation · Me

STAGE 2 / 12

Thinking adds a layer.

The mind starts generating — meanings, motives, predictions, judgments. Each thought adds new information onto the target. An aura forgets its form.

STAGE 3 / 12

Then it sticks. That's Saran Wrap.

The layer keeps feeding the thinking and starts to feel like the target itself. You're not looking at them — you see through it. What the mind added now looks like plain fact.

STAGE 4 / 12

One state. A different story.

Which story gets generated isn't decided by the facts. It's decided by your energy state. Change the state and the mind auto-completes the same target a completely different way.

Calm / Open · Wired · Turbulence · Collapsed

STAGE 5 / 12

It's never only mental.

Every narrative state comes with a body state and an action set. Posture, breath, tension, behavior — they move together, as one package.

Calm / Open · Wired · Turbulence · Collapsed

STAGE 6 / 12

A repeating package is a mode.

When the same narrative, energy, body stress, and behavior keep showing up together, the combination is a mode. Any combination that repeats. You don't just think anxious — the whole system enters anxious.

Calm / Open · Wired · Turbulence · Collapsed

STAGE 7 / 12

You move through modes all day.

Different contexts summon different modes — work modes, relational modes, family modes, solitude modes. Each one arrives with its own story, body, and behavior, and each one feels like "just how things are" while it's running.

Calm / Open · Wired · Turbulence · Collapsed

STAGE 8 / 12

Sometimes one state runs underneath them all.

A dominant energy state — wanted, depressive, stoked — can color every mode in the day. Different rooms, different roles, same undertone. That baseline is usually the last thing to work with, not any single incident.

Calm / Open · Wired · Turbulence · Collapsed

STAGE 9 / 12

Now add a second flashlight.

Two people, one event, two wraps. Each person argues with the world the other's mind has built — and neither can see the other's beam, or their own. Both feel correct. Both feel attacked.

STAGE 10 / 12

When the wrap hardens, that's lock.

A story defended long enough stops feeling like a story. It locks — sets the events, sets the other person, sets who you are in it. From inside a lock, certainty feels like clarity. It's usually just grip.

STAGE 11 / 12

The practice is subtraction.

The stories about yourself get more forgiving. The stories about others get more open — less beholden to the past. The future stops being a verdict and becomes room room to breathe. room for optimism. room to lay down new tracks. Nothing was added to get here. Things were just drawn.

STAGE 12 / 12

Just this.

That's the whole point.

Just this. That's the whole point.

"The whole world is created by mind alone."

— ANONYMOUS, 17 Fig.

Find out what yours is.

Read the full theory →

THE PROGRAM

Five stages, one dream — yours

Everything above is the theory. This is the part you actually do. A guide follows, makes a case for what it thinks is running in your life, and builds you a map you can look at — then the practical work of living differently with it.

How it works →

1 **Gather** What does this life actually look like?	2 **Map the dream** Seeing the whole shape at once.	3 **Manage the dream** What is actually yours to do	4 **Master** Living with it, over time.	5 **Wake up** Loosening the grip.

Start the first conversation — No account. Stored in your browser.

© 2026 Narrative Theory. Not therapy, diagnosis, or crisis support.

Five stages · no account · free while in demo

Everyone is walking around inside a dream.

Not a delusion — a dream. Thinking lays a film over things, and after enough years the film stops feeling like interpretation and starts feeling like plain fact. This is just how people are. This is just how I am. Narrative Theory calls that film *Saran Wrap*; the older word is *maya*.

The dream is not made of lies. It is made of real observations, mostly accurate ones, wired into a shape that stopped being checked a long time ago. That is why it is so durable, and why arguing with it rarely does anything.

This is a guided program for finding out what yours actually is. You talk; a guide listens, makes a case for what it thinks is running, and builds you a map you can look at. Then the practical part: what is yours to do about it, what to try, and eventually how to catch the film while it is on rather than three days later.

Start the first conversation

Stored in your browser. Nothing to sign up for.

How it goes

1 **Gather**

A long, unhurried conversation about what hurts, who you are around, and how the world tends to look to you. Nothing is being fixed yet. The only goal is an accurate picture.

You end up with: A set of observations, in your own language, that you can correct.

2 **Map the dream**

Together you work out what the dream actually is — what sets it off, the world it produces, the specific ways it makes things look, and what keeps happening as a result. It ends as a single diagram you can look at.

You end up with: A live map of the dream: triggers, world, lenses, consequences.

3 **Manage the dream**

The practical stage. What you are responsible for, what to do when the dream fires, and — said in advance — the specific ways this tends to go wrong so it does not surprise you.

You end up with: A working plan: issues, response options, and if-then protocols.

4 **Monitor**

Missions with real success conditions, and honest check-ins over weeks — including the ones where nothing happened. What you learn here goes back into the map.

You end up with: Active missions and a check-in history.

5 **Wake up**

Everything before this was about the contents of the dream. This is about the fact of dreaming — attention, stillness, and noticing the film while it is on rather than afterward.

You end up with: A small set of practices aimed at your specific map.

Worth saying plainly

This is not therapy and the guide is not a therapist. If you are in crisis or in danger, this is the wrong tool — go to a person. In the US you can call or text 988.

It will make claims about you. That is the point, and it is also the risk. The guide proposes; you correct it. Anything it puts on your map stays a guess — drawn with a dashed outline — until you actually agree with it. Being told “no, that’s wrong” is a normal part of this working.

It is light on the past. The program asks about your history but does not treat any single event as the cause of any single pattern. People are not that legible, and a tidy origin story is usually a story.

Your record lives in this browser. No account, no server-side copy. Clear your browser data and it is gone; open it on your phone and it is not there.

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Gather

What does this life actually look like?

Let's start wherever it's easiest. What's been sitting with you lately — the thing you'd mention first if a friend asked how you were actually doing?

Take your time.

Send

Notes Map Plan Missions Practice

What the guide picks up collects here as you talk. If something looks wrong, say so — an inaccurate picture is worse than an empty one.

Everything here is stored in this browser only — nothing is sent to an account. Save a copy if it matters to you. What this is

© 2026 Narrative Theory. Not therapy, diagnosis, or crisis support.

THE THEORY

A theory of how mind becomes world.

Narrative Theory studies how experience is constructed. Most of what we call "reality" arrives already wrapped in story: memory, meaning, expectation, identity, even the sense of being a continuous self. This theory asks how that happens, why it's so strong, and what it's happening that we mostly miss because the thing itself.

The framework draws from Zen practice, cognitive psychology, ethology, psychotherapy, and patient observation of one's own mind. Its claim is simple: the story is not the territory, but it is the territory we live in. Change the story and you change experience. A quiet partner stops being contempt. A room stops being a hierarchy. What looked like the world revolves back into the world, plus a mind constructing a version of it.

In a meeting where you feel small, the smallness is rarely in the room — it's in a sizzling system the mind is running underneath. A flight that won't land, what feels like the truth is usually a tactical narrative on both sides. In therapy, the work is rarely finding the right story. It's noticing when a story is a chain of evidence. These are not theories of perception. They are how perception works until it's seen.

JUMP TO CORE VOCABULARY THE DIAGRAMS GENDER THEORY ACKNOWLEDGMENTS DISAGREES AS MODES BEHAVE

THE CORE VOCABULARY

Core vocabulary

Construction
The assembled world you actually live in — senses plus story, determined by all three.

Sense Wrap
The immediate layer of story wrapped around reality.

Body + Energy States
The physical and energetic side of experience: breath, tension, posture, speed, charge, flavor.

Mode
A recurring package of thinking style, body energy, and action.

Rank
The felt social hierarchy projected onto rooms and relationships.

Correct Function
Every mode in the situation calls for — and doing it.

Life Review
Practice application of NT to one's recurring patterns.

Thought-or-Longtime
The real story and its ambiguous situations, and the fitting is colored by your energy state.

Checking
The reflex of monitoring your own state and performance, which is itself the problem.

Dehydrated Narrative
A story with its emotional content removed. It no longer looks like a story. It feels like truth.

Expectation Narrative
The pre-written script of how a situation is going to go, usually mistaken for reality.

Locus of Normal
The felt sense of whose way of being counts as "normal" in the room.

Narrative Grammar
The underlying rules of sentence, being assembled in your story-finding experience.

Performance Mode (The Act)
The role you step into when stakes appear — and the contract it costs you.

Storypoints
Specific facts, a-ha's, events, emphasizers, and dots to build to the story.

Narrative
Thought that fuels an opinion about a target — and then becomes part of how the target appears.

Thinking · Body · Action
The three channels of data, and behavior pulse together as one package.

Narrative Styles / Flavors
The distinctive, recognizable ways a mode of thinking, anxious, arrogant, harmonic, suspicious, playful.

Scoring System
The mode's internal scorecard for whether it's working.

Narrative Lock
When a story becomes so certain it no longer feels like a story.

Being · Doing
Being is what you are when you're not doing.

Cue, Clumps, Sequences, Modes, and Pattern
How the mind chains continuous reality into things, events, and patterns.

The Dream (Maya / Lograghaya)
The dream of separation and of escaping the mind-projects and then loses bonds, interesting, in the waking.

The End of Trying (Formerly The Shift)
The paradox at the center of the practice: the effort to relax is itself the tension.

Assaulting the Metamor
The constant internal war-zone we all live with in exactly him, in favor of what you want were here.

The Fight Contest
Rank and worth treated as a real competition, when the scoreboard is invented.

Frames & Frame Dynamics
A frame is your working construction of a situation, when frames meet, there are rules.

Thought Melodies
The recurring tunes over time the music — and every melody is a key.

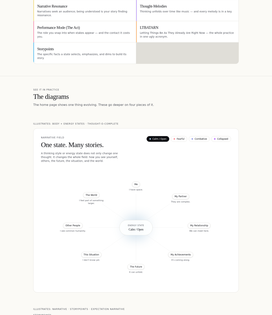
LITERATURES
Lankavatara Sutra (5c A. Thru), Shrimala Jan Night Nun — the whole practice in one ugly acronym.

SEE IT IN PRACTICE

The diagrams

The home page shows one thing working. These go deeper on four pieces of it.

ILLUSTRATED · BODY + ENERGY STATES · THOUGHT IS COMPLETE

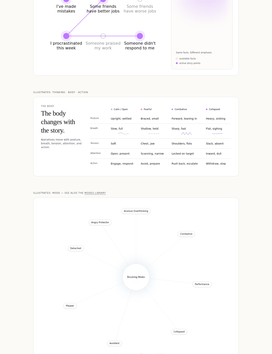


THE DIAGRAMS

One story. Many stories.

A thinking style or energy state does not only change one thought. It changes the whole field. How you see yourself, others, the future, the situation, and the world.

ILLUSTRATED · NARRATIVE · STORYPOINTS · EXPECTATION NARRATIVE



Same facts. Different storypoints.

An energy state highlights some facts and dims others. The facts stay the same, but the story path changes.

ILLUSTRATED · THINKING · BODY · ACTION

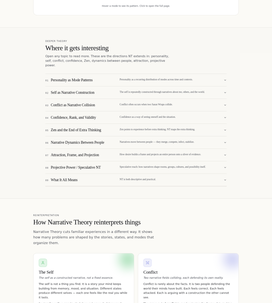
THE BODY

The body changes with the story.

Sensations move with posture, breath, tension, attention, and energy.

	Calm / Open	Fearful	Contained	Collapsed
Posture	Upright, settled	Braced, small	Forward, leaning in	Heavy, sinking
Breath	Slow, full	Shallow, held	Steady, fast	Flat, sighing
Tension	Soft	Chest, jaw	Shoulders, fists	Slack, absent
Energy	Open, present	Scanning, narrow	Locked on target	Inward, dull
Action	Engage, respond	Avoid, prepare	Push back, escalate	Withdraw, stop

ILLUSTRATED · MODES — SEE ALSO THE MODES LIBRARY



DEEPER THEORY

Where it gets interesting

Some are hard to resist here. Those are the directions NT extends in: personality, self-conflict, confidence, Zen, dynamics between people, attraction, psytrance power.

Personality as Mode Patterns	Personality as a recurring tendency of modes across time and contexts.
Self as Narrative Construction	The self is repeatedly constructed through narratives about its values, and the world.
Conflict as Narrative Collision	Conflict often occurs when two fixed narratives about reality collide.
Confidence, Rank, and Validity	Confidence is a way of seeing oneself and the situation.
Zen and the End of Extra Thinking	Zen points to experience before over-thinking. NT maps the over-thinking.
Narrative Dynamics Between People	Personal transformation people — two-body contains other entities.
Attraction, Frame, and Narrative	How does healthy attraction work as a system, and what does it look like?
Projective Power / Specialistic NT	Narrative tools have repetitive stage-scenes, groups, others, and possibly itself.
What It All Means	NT is what description and practice.

DEEPER THEORY

How Narrative Theory reinterprets things

Narrative Theory can't define everything. Its real value is in different way. It shows how many problems are shaped by the stories, states, and modes that organize them.

The Self

The self as a constructed narrative, not a fixed essence.

The self is not a thing you find. It is a story your mind keeps telling, updating, and defending. Different modes produce different selves — each one feels like the real you while it runs.

Seeing the self as constructed does not erase it. It lessens it.

Attraction

Attraction is the engine that builds a whole person from a sliver of evidence.

Attraction is a story the mind generates fast — a person, a tone, a moment — and then it starts looking for more of what works, and for future. A whole field.

What looks like seeing the other is often projecting onto them. Attraction is the most powerful projection. It shapes the frame from meeting the person.

Certainty

Certainty is a mode of the victim, not a property of the facts.

Certainty feels like a narrative free from doubt. It signals clear, not a measurement of how true it is. The same person, in a different mode, feels the previous certainty completely wrong.

Most overconfidence is state-conformance mistaken for evidence.

Conflict

Two modes in fixed conflict, each defending its own reality.

Conflict is rarely about the facts. It is two people defending the stories that make them feel safe, right, or worthy. Each one is attacked. Each is arguing with a construction the other cannot see.

The deeper cut of conflict is anxiety entering the frame. It is making contact with the person under it.

Charisma

Charisma is a mode a person carries into a room.

Charisma is the strength and stability of someone's narrative field. A confident person walking into an anxious room can shift the emotional gravity. People feel pulled into a steadier story.

It is less a trait than a state someone can hold long enough to share.

Depression & Anxiety

Depression and anxiety are not a narrative about self, future, and world.

Anxiety is a future-heavy narrative running on a body bracced for threat. Depression is a narrative about self running narratives of closure, defeat, and powerlessness.

Those are not just feelings. They are stable arrangements of mind, body, and story that isolate themselves for a while.

Personality

A recurring distribution of modes across time and contexts.

Personality is not a box you're in. It is the pattern of which modes a person tends to reach for. The science has a name for this: Activity Mode. The version proposed here is simpler. The repeated pattern that we observe from the outside.

A person is not identical to their patterns. They are the field in which patterns appear and dissolve.

Disorders

Modes that have become rigid, frequent, and self-reinforcing.

When a mode becomes rigid, frequent, and self-reinforcing, it can start to look like a disorder. The science has a name for this: Activity Mode. The version proposed here is simpler. The repeated pattern that we observe from the outside.

A person is not identical to their patterns. They are the field in which patterns appear and dissolve.

Value-Collapse Mode

A mode in which the person has lost the sense of direction or worth of something.

RELATED
Depression, Anxiety, Avoidant, Authority, Narcissistic Collapse

Read further →

Attachment Emergency Mode

Relationship instability appears as survival threat.

RELATED
Borderline patterns, anxious attachment, avoidant withdrawal, relationship-as-survival dynamics

Read further →

Control & Certainty Mode

Uncertainty, inconsistency, contamination, and loss of control are experienced as threat.

RELATED
OCD, health anxiety, eating disorder control traits, perfectionistic rigidity

Read further →

Belief & Escape Mode

The current state feels intolerable, and an alternative reality is sought to escape it.

RELATED
Substance use, dissociation, grief, addiction, delusional thinking, escapist fantasy

Read further →

Reality & Interface Mode

Social media, gaming, online identity, and community, or social meaning becomes more real than embodied relationship.

RELATED
Addiction, dissociation, gaming disorder, parasocial relationship patterns

Read further →

WHERE MODES OVERCOME

The organizing logic at a glance

Each mode has a different organizing logic. NT does not begin with the diagnosis. It begins with the mode and how it runs.

These are terms, not treatment. Real disorders deserve real care.

CLUSTER	MODE	THINKING STYLE	BODY SENSATIONS	BEHAVIOR	DEFENSE MECHANISM	COMMON IN
Three Modes	Functioning, Grounded	Future, body, and relationships in balance	Flexibility, regulation, and ease	Moving, engaging, and adapting	Rare / Healthy	Anxiety, depression, trauma, addiction
Three & Rank Modes	Low-esteem Mode	Self is relative to others	Comparison, self-monitoring, lack of ease, and constant tone of mental	Overworking, over-functioning, and people-pleasing	Shame / Status Fear	Perfectionism, anxiety, depression, trauma, addiction
Three Collapse Modes	Collapse Mode	Self, life, and relationships are pointless	Deep exhaustion, numbness, and heaviness	Withdrawal, isolation, and loss of motivation	Dissociation / Depersonalization	Depression, trauma, addiction
Control & Certainty Mode	Control Mode	Uncertainty feels contaminated, dangerous, or out of control	Tension, tightness, and physical rigidity	Checking, washing, avoiding, and ritualizing	Control / Contamination Fear	Anxiety, OCD, trauma, addiction
Emergency Mode	Emergency Mode	Everything is a threat	Hypervigilance, startle, and physical tension	Fleeing, fighting, freezing, or collapsing	Dissociation / Numbness	Trauma, anxiety, addiction
Belief & Escape Mode	Belief Mode	Reality, self, and others need to be changed, escaped, or replaced	Private sensing, emotional numbness, and altered consciousness	Changing beliefs, substances, or perceptions	Splitting / Dissociation	Trauma, addiction, psychosis
Reality & Interface Mode	Reality Mode	Reality, self, and others have become unstable or unreliable	Private sensing, emotional numbness, and altered consciousness	Changing beliefs, substances, or perceptions	Splitting / Dissociation	Trauma, addiction, psychosis

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FIELD GUIDE

Mode Library

A mode is a repeating package of thinking style, body state, energy, and action. You enter and leave them. You are not identical to them.

+ Submit a mode

Modes are recurring clusters of narrative, body, and action.

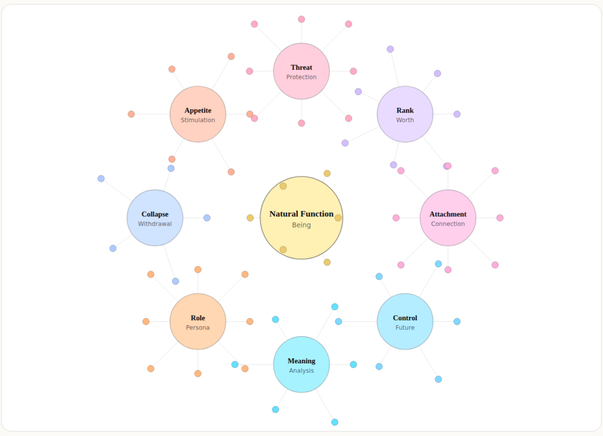
A narrative style does not operate by itself. It usually travels with a body state, a way of seeing reality, and a set of action tendencies.

When the same pattern keeps returning — anxious overthinking, combativeness, collapse, rejection, perfectionism — that pattern is a mode.

Modes are useful because they help you recognize the states you keep entering, what they make you believe, and what they make you do.

You do not need to become a mode expert. The point is to recognize your own recurring modes and learn how to loosen them.

NETWORK



Hover to label, click for the four-row definition.

FAMILIES

- **Threat / Protection**
  Mind treats the situation as a possible danger. Body braces; story scans for risk.
  8 modes
- **Rank / Worth**
  Life becomes a scoreboard. The self is measured against others and against an internal ideal.
  7 modes
- **Attachment / Connection**
  The bond becomes the world. Closeness, distance, and signals are read with high charge.
  8 modes
- **Control / Future**
  Mind tries to manage what hasn't happened. Steering replaces being.
  6 modes
- **Meaning / Analysis**
  Thinking about thinking. Frameworks, theories, and explanations multiply.
  6 modes
- **Role / Persona**
  A package of self is assembled for a context: work-self, family-self, dating-self.
  8 modes
- **Collapse / Withdrawal**
  Energy folds inward. The story shrinks the world; engagement falls.
  5 modes
- **Appetite / Stimulation**
  Wanting and seeking. The mind reaches toward stimulation as relief or escape.
  6 modes
- **Natural Function / Being**
  Modes of clear contact and natural function. Less story between action and situation.
  6 modes

ALL MODES

Search modes…

All families

60 of 60

- THREAT / PROTECTION
  Alert Mode
  Scanning for threat.
- THREAT / PROTECTION
  Anxiety Mode
  The future becomes a threat object.
- THREAT / PROTECTION
  Social Anxiety Mode
  The room becomes a courtroom.
- THREAT / PROTECTION
  Fight Mode
  Win the frame, defend the self.
- THREAT / PROTECTION
  Freeze Mode
  No move feels safe.
- THREAT / PROTECTION
  Defense Mode
  Set the record straight.
- THREAT / PROTECTION
  Appeasement Mode
  Keep the peace by shrinking.
- THREAT / PROTECTION
  Avoidance Mode
  Do anything except the thing.
- RANK / WORTH
  Progress Mode
  Life becomes a scoreboard.
- RANK / WORTH
  Performance Mode
  Become the version they will approve of.
- RANK / WORTH
  Comparison Mode
  Someone else becomes evidence against you.
- RANK / WORTH
  Shame Mode
  The self becomes the problem.
- RANK / WORTH
  Validation-Seeking Mode
  Borrow worth from outside.
- RANK / WORTH
  Inferiority Mode
  Everyone else gets credit; you get flaws.
- RANK / WORTH
  Impress Mode
  Make them see your value.
- ATTACHMENT / CONNECTION
  Relationship Mode
  The bond becomes the whole world.
- ATTACHMENT / CONNECTION
  Romantic Projection Mode
  Falling for the person your mind drafted.
- ATTACHMENT / CONNECTION
  Chase Mode
  Closeness must be secured now.
- ATTACHMENT / CONNECTION
  Withdrawal Mode
  Safety through distance.
- ATTACHMENT / CONNECTION
  Resentment Mode
  Old injury keeps charging the present.
- ATTACHMENT / CONNECTION
  Testing Mode
  Make them prove they care.
- ATTACHMENT / CONNECTION
  Dating Strategy Mode
  Attraction becomes a project.
- ATTACHMENT / CONNECTION
  Breakup Replay Mode
  Keep the bond alive by replaying the wound.
- CONTROL / FUTURE
  Planning Mode
  If I solve the future, I can relax.
- CONTROL / FUTURE
  Fix-It Mode
  Turn discomfort into a project.
- CONTROL / FUTURE
  Mental Manager Mode
  The commentator takes the wheel.
- CONTROL / FUTURE
  Trying-to-Relax Mode
  Trying hard to stop trying.
- CONTROL / FUTURE
  Rehearsal Mode
  Have the conversation before it happens.
- CONTROL / FUTURE
  Life-Management Mode
  Manage the whole life from above.
- MEANING / ANALYSIS
  Thinking Mode
  The mind becomes the place you live.
- MEANING / ANALYSIS
  Reflective Mode
  Looking at experience from a little distance.
- MEANING / ANALYSIS
  Theory-Building Mode
  Turn life into a model.
- MEANING / ANALYSIS
  Buddhist Speculation Mode
  Use philosophy to hover above life.
- MEANING / ANALYSIS
  Puzzle Mode
  Something must be solved.
- MEANING / ANALYSIS
  Meta Mode
  Think about the thinking about the thinking.
- ROLE / PERSONA
  Work Mode
  Competence package activated.
- ROLE / PERSONA
  Good Child Mode
  Stay acceptable to the family system.
- ROLE / PERSONA
  Teacher Mode
  Make it useful for someone else.
- ROLE / PERSONA
  Helper Mode
  Relieve their suffering, maybe yours too.
- ROLE / PERSONA
  Seducer Mode
  Become charged and desirable.
- ROLE / PERSONA
  Spiritual Person Mode
  Perform being beyond performance.
- ROLE / PERSONA
  Bar Social Mode
  Group energy, status, and play collide.
- ROLE / PERSONA
  Family Time Mode
  Old roles come back online.
- COLLAPSE / WITHDRAWAL
  Collapse Mode
  The system powers down.
- COLLAPSE / WITHDRAWAL
  Doom Mode
  The worst story becomes the whole sky.
- COLLAPSE / WITHDRAWAL
  Numb Mode
  Nothing gets through.
- COLLAPSE / WITHDRAWAL
  Isolation Mode
  Safety by disappearing.
- COLLAPSE / WITHDRAWAL
  Disengagement Mode
  Fuck it, none of this matters.
- APPETITE / STIMULATION
  Craving Mode
  Something else will fix this.
- APPETITE / STIMULATION
  Scroll Mode
  Tiny stimulation to avoid contact.
- APPETITE / STIMULATION
  Novelty Mode
  Newness promises aliveness.
- APPETITE / STIMULATION
  Substance Mode
  Change the state from the outside.
- APPETITE / STIMULATION
  More Mode
  Enough is one step away.
- APPETITE / STIMULATION
  Social Media Mode
  The world becomes comparison feed.
- NATURAL FUNCTION / BEING
  Drumming Flow Mode
  Listen more than you manage.
- NATURAL FUNCTION / BEING
  Creative Expression Mode
  Make before the critic arrives.
- NATURAL FUNCTION / BEING
  Listening Mode
  Let the other person become real.
- NATURAL FUNCTION / BEING
  Play Mode
  Action without self-importance.
- NATURAL FUNCTION / BEING
  Care Function
  Help because the situation calls for it.
- NATURAL FUNCTION / BEING
  Meditation Mode
  Practice as a container.

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PRACTICAL LIBRARY

Life Instruction™

Modules that apply the theory to real situations: confidence, conflict, relationships, anxiety, grief, meditation, meaning. Read the article. Try the exercise. Loosen the pattern.

Search Life Instruction...

47 modules across 11 shelves

Start Here / Core Practice

View shelf →

CORE NT PRACTICES
Life Review

CORE NT PRACTICES
Seeing vs. Making

CORE NT PRACTICES
Name the Mode

CORE NT PRACTICES
What Exists Right Now?

CORE NT PRACTICES
The Body Channel

How You See Yourself

View shelf →

HOW YOU SEE YOURSELF
Self-Worth

HOW YOU SEE YOURSELF
Confidence and Rank

HOW YOU SEE YOURSELF
Being Hard on Yourself

HOW YOU SEE YOURSELF
Body Image

HOW YOU SEE YOURSELF
Anxiety and Worry

Social Anxiety and Social Life

View shelf →

SOCIAL ANXIETY AND PERFORMANCE
Social Anxiety Breakdown

SOCIAL ANXIETY AND PERFORMANCE
Conversation Pressure

SOCIAL ANXIETY AND PERFORMANCE
Being Seen

Relationships

View shelf →

THE ONGOING RELATIONSHIP
Staying Close

THE ONGOING RELATIONSHIP
When You Fight

THE ONGOING RELATIONSHIP
Relating With Courage

ATTRACTION AND DESIRE
Attraction

BREAKUPS
After a Breakup

Anger and Conflict

View shelf →

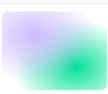
THE ANGER MODE
Working With Anger

CONFLICT-SEEKING AND COOLING DOWN
Conflict as a Way of Life

Zen and Letting Go

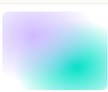
View shelf →

UNDERSTANDING ZEN
Understanding Zen



UNDERSTANDING ZEN
Being / Doing

UNDERSTANDING ZEN
Don't-Know Mind



UNDERSTANDING ZEN
The Ten Bulls

MEDITATION AND LETTIN
Trying to Do Zen

Letting Go

View shelf →

THE END OF TRYING
The End of Trying

THE END OF TRYING
How to Listen

Flow and Natural Function

View shelf →

FLOW, PLAY, AND CORRECT FUNCTION
Drumming and Flow

FLOW, PLAY, AND CORRECT FUNCTION
Dancing With the Beat

FLOW, PLAY, AND CORRECT FUNCTION
Correct Function

FLOW, PLAY, AND CORRECT FUNCTION
Natural Function vs. Mode

Grief and Loss

View shelf →

GRIEF
Grief

Meaning and Service

View shelf →

MEANING AND VIRTUE
What Matters

MEANING AND VIRTUE
Service and Kindness

Disorders Through an NT Lens

View shelf →

EDUCATIONAL REFRAMES
Anxiety Through NT

EDUCATIONAL REFRAMES
Depression Through NT

EDUCATIONAL REFRAMES
Social Anxiety Through NT

EDUCATIONAL REFRAMES
OCD Through NT

EDUCATIONAL REFRAMES
ADHD Through NT

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TOOL

Bring a Situation

Describe what you are caught in right now. The page will return a Narrative Theory reading: camera view, saran view, possible modes, body cues, and practice to try.

YOUR SITUATION

e.g. Sent a text last night, no reply. Now I'm spinning, checking my phone, reading old messages.

Please do not include names, contact info, or identifying details of others.

Run reading Reset

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ABOUT

What is Narrative Theory?

People have asked what Narrative Theory is all about. Here's the short version — three to five minutes. Assembled almost entirely from the notebooks it grew up in.

Where it comes from

Narrative Theory is a way to break down and make sense of our experience. It was born out of personal observation, Zen practice, psychology, animal behavior, and an honest disappointment in contemporary psychotherapy. It's a map — of relationships, conflict, happiness, and everything in between — so you can understand your own situations with clarity, and see their solutions.

Another way to say it: NT is the psychology of Zen. It starts from the clear mind — the one you find at the end of a long retreat, after real grief, in deep rest — and asks: what is that mind, and what is everything else? It is the book I couldn't find on the shelf, so it had to be written.

The basic claim

You can experience reality two fundamentally different ways: with noisy habitual thinking, and without. NT looks to understand everything through that one dichotomy.

When the mind is quiet, the world is less divided. Situations are less gloomy. Other people become ordinary and near. The natural impulse to help comes online by itself, without a philosophy attached.

When the mind is noisy, we live inside a constructed world — reality cut into pieces, each piece wrapped in an identity, a value, a rank we projected onto it — and then we defend that world as if we had found it rather than made it.

The Saran Wrap

We are always harboring thoughts, and those thoughts are projected outward into perception. We don't notice, because the projection maps perfectly onto reality — like plastic wrap pulled tight over a fruit. It fits so well and it's so clear that you can't see it's there.

But sometimes it peels. The moment you decide to stop fighting, and the person you hated becomes a person again. The end of a retreat. Real loss. Deep relaxation. Then you see what things are like without the commentary: quiet, connected, unranked, simpler than the story said. That glimpse is the beginning of the whole practice — once you have seen the wrap as wrap, you can never fully unsee it.

Modes

We move through the day in modes: repeating packages of thinking style, body state, energy, and action that arrive together and leave together. A mode is a little world. Inside Anxiety Mode the future is dangerous. Inside Fight Mode the other person is guilty. Inside Progress Mode your life is a scoreboard, and you're behind.

The key mechanism is the feedback loop: a mode's actions reinforce the world that produced them. Anxiety avoids, and avoidance makes danger feel more real. The mode solves the moment and deepens the pattern. That is why these things get sticky — and why naming the mode, feeling its body signature, and watching its sequence is already the start of the exit.

Rank, frames, and the fake contest

Much of social life is a quiet contest over whose frame governs and whose way of being counts as normal. Rank feels real — the felt hierarchy of every room — but the scoreboard is invented, and it flickers with your state, which is the giveaway. Certainty transfers; doubt defers. None of this needs to be won. It needs to be seen.

The Shift

Healing, in NT, is not narrative editing. We don't try to swap bad stories for better ones — that's redecorating the cell. The Shift is a change from resistance to surrender: the cessation of wanting this moment to be different, the end of trying.

Wanting is the fuel of the thinking machine. Remove the fuel and the machinery quiets on its own — the wrap thins, the body unclenches, and wisdom and warmth come up by themselves, uninvited. You cannot force this. Forcing is the opposite motion. You can only position yourself — sit down, stop steering, let things be as they already are right now — and let it happen to you.

What NT is not

It is not therapy, and it's not a substitute for it. It is not positive thinking. It is not about killing thought — the mind is no hindrance; thoughts come and go, and you simply stop being their vehicle. And it is not a finished doctrine. It's a working map, drawn from the inside, still being drawn.

Kindness is woven into all of this. Not the end goal — more the end state. When the contest quiets and the wrap thins, care is just what's left.

The point

The goal is not to make perfect categories. There are no perfect categories. The goal is to see clearly enough that we stop being possessed by the categories and worlds we create — and then to live from there: simpler, warmer, with both feet in the actual moment.

Now practice that.

Do the program → Learn the vocabulary

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